Abbott Laboratories

Key Takeaways from Our 3Q26 Call with Management

Overweight

ABT, ABT US
Price (20 Oct 26):$102.45

Medical Supplies & Devices

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There's a lot to digest with Abbott's earnings print today, some of which is good, some of which is debatable, and some of which is not so good. For starters, we like the nutrition spin and advocated for as much earlier this year. It removes a non-core business with a very different growth and margin profile, and it could be an interesting asset profile for a dividend & income focused investor with a good FCF profile. The guidance outlook for 2027 is moving lower, and here we deem this debatable. Prior commentary pointed to ~7.5% organic growth and ~10% EPS growth; we now think comments on the call imply ~6% organic and $5.90 (+7%) in EPS for 2027, and we fully expect the Street to hover around these metrics following today. It's debatable in the sense that we think this is the final cut after a string of negative revisions and doesn't factor in many of the known/likely positives (discussed below); however, with lowered outlooks in key growth drivers CGM and Exact, investors will likely need a few more proof points before calling the all-clear signal. We'd advocated across the board in MedTech for conservative, seemingly derisked guides for 2027 as investors want to own upside and avoid potential downside debates. Abbott has over the past year leaned into a guide that was more better case than conservative base case, and our sense is the feedback has been registered and there's been a shift in philiospohy. Only time will tell, but our sense is all the negatives are mostly factored in and few to none of the positives are, particlarly in CGM assumpstion. As for the negatives, it's what was expected (LAA, both market weakness and a sharp decline in orders ahead of Amulet 360 approval as early as December, modest Exact weakness vs. expectations) and the unexpected (CGM, both OUS pricing headwinds and US deceleration until CMS T2 non-insulin coverage starts, which is still TBD). The net result is that numbers are moving lower, the multiple should probably move a touch lower, but there's value creation potential with the spin, all of which we think the price action today fairly captures. **The question is whether this is a buying opportunity or not? Honestly, much depends on the rest of MedTech and the market fund flows into or out of Healthcare and MedTech. We think a seemingly derisked 2027 guide for ABT with 6% organic growth could be interesting at 17x 2027E EPS, but we think many will wait for management to prove on 4Q that the cuts are in the rearview and numbers can start to revise higher in 2027 – beats and raises drive share prices higher.**

- **We think the value proposition of the separation is clear – it should improve top-line growth and margins, and remove what's been a difficult business of late, both for Abbott specifically and the packaged goods/ nutrition market overall (see our detailed February note on the topic here).** The strategic rationale for keeping the two businesses together has weakened over time as Nutrition has gone from being viewed as a healthcare market to one that's now shaped by consumer preferences, wellness trends, and retail execution. Management expects the separation to accelerate sales growth 50-100bps and expand gross margin by >200bps and operating margin 100bps. Abbott plans to complete the separation by the end of next year, both companies will maintain investment grade ratings, and the stand-alone Nutrition company will raise debt with a portion of the proceeds to be distributed to Abbott. Both Abbott and the stand-alone Nutrition business will pay a dividend that when combined will meet Abbott's dividend at the time of the separation – we expect

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a higher Nutrition dividend vs. RemainCo.

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- **On balance, a potential Nutrition separation should be net neutral to slightly beneficial for Abbott valuation, in our view; in either case, we think investors would welcome it given the challenges this business has posed.** While Nutrition has not been a recent investment focus, the dollars currently allocated there would likely earn a higher ROIC in Devices or Diagnostics. Assuming a ~12x multiple on 2027E net income for Nutrition (a slight discount to peers in light of execution and legal challenges) and ~19x on Abbott RemainCo (a two-turn increase relative to the current multiple for an additional 50-100bps of growth), we arrive at a combined Nutrition plus RemainCo market cap at least comparable to WholeCo Abbott today (i.e., 1 + 1 should equal at least 2, if our assumptions hold).
- **Guidance for 2026 moving slightly lower on the top line (now ~6.0% comparable) is understandably a disappointment, though we think this is ultimately the right move given the 4Q step up had always been viewed as a stretch and the incremental challenges that emerged in the quarter.** This implies ~8.0% comparable growth in 4Q, below the ~10% the Street was forecasting prior, which we think reflects a combination of what seems to be a more prudent approach to guidance and new challenges emerging in certain areas of the business. We'd call out: (1) EP, where softer than expected trends in Amulet due to both LAAC market challenges and destocking ahead of the Amulet 360 launch in December should result in 4Q growth of ~20%, down from our expectation for ~25% prior; (2) Diabetes, with growth likely landing ~3.5% due to OUS pricing pressure, delayed tenders in basal, and slower than expected uptake in non-intensive type 2. Growth should remain in this low- to mid-single-digit range until catalysts like non-intensive type 2 coverage, basal coverage expansion OUS, or Libre Duo uptake kick in.
- **Looking down the P&L, 4Q EPS guidance is $1.62-1.67 bracketing the Street at $1.64, with management pointing to $1.64 on ~8.0% comparable sales growth and 7.6% organic sales growth.** Gross margin should step up to ~57.8% in 4Q from 57.2% in 3Q, which expanded 140bps Y/Y on favorable mix within legacy Abbott, the addition of Exact, and operational improvements. R&D should run at ~6.5% of sales and SG&A at ~24.9%, a step below 6.9% and 26.9% in 3Q. Total below-the-line expense is expected to be ~$130M with a 15.2% tax rate and ~1,740M diluted shares, while FX should be a ~100bps headwind to 4Q sales and a ~$0.02 headwind to EPS, matching 3Q.
- **Management's early 2027 framework we believe calls for ~6% organic sales growth including Nutrition, or ~6.7-7.0% excluding Nutrition, down from the +6.5-8.5% organic growth and double-digit EPS growth it pointed to last quarter and ~$5.90 in EPS, roughly $0.15 below the Street.** The framework leaves out CMS coverage for non-intensive T2 CGM and includes only a modest Libre Duo contribution. It also assumes China Core Lab declines mid single digits again and EP VBP in China starts January 1. By segment, it includes EP at ~18%, Cancer Diagnostics at ~12%, Diabetes at ~4.5%, and Nutrition at ~3%, with EPS at ~$5.90. Formal guidance is expected in January.
- **Diving deeper into the segments, and starting with Medical Devices:**
- **Diabetes sales of $2.19B (+6.7%cc) missed by $17M, as a US beat (+9.4%, + $13M) was more than offset by OUS (+4.9% comparable, -$30M), where the vast majority of pricing pressure is coming from lower-priced Chinese CGMs.** Libre grew +10.8% in the US to $842M and +5.8% OUS to $1.26B. Chinese competitors have not gained a material foothold outside Russia, but Abbott has given price concessions to protect its 50-70% share in major international markets,

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with OUS price per patient moving toward ~$1,000 from ~$1,200 two years ago. Abbott is pairing those concessions with longer-term contracts and expects COGS programs to offset the margin impact. For the next few quarters, and until catalysts such as non-intensive T2 coverage, OUS basal expansion, and Libre Duo uptake arrive, we expect US CGM growth of ~5-6% and OUS growth of ~3-4%. The lack of non-intensive T2 coverage in the US and pricing and later basal tenders OUS are each costing ~4-5 points of growth. Diabetes is guided to ~3.5% in 4Q (CGM ~4-4.5%) and ~4.5% in 2027 (CGM ~5%), including a 50-75bps fingerstick headwind. Management views non-intensive T2 coverage as a matter of when and not if, with the middle of 2027 the earliest under a normal comment period, and none of it is in the forecast. Libre Duo launches in the US in December with only a modest contribution embedded, and a favorable US payer formulary change takes effect January 1.

- **Electrophysiology sales of $873M (+15.5%cc) missed by $29M on LAA as market headwinds and a slowdown in US Amulet orders following the Amulet 360 CE Mark offset strong ablation growth.** Ex-LAA, EP grew in the high teens worldwide and ~20-25% in the US versus +18.1% reported, while LAA sales fell to just above $25M from $55M in 3Q25. Ablation catheter growth came in well above 2-3x market growth (i.e., above our 42% forecast), with US Volt adoption accelerating in September following the full market release in mid August. Volt is doing well despite perforation concerns, with its event rate per procedure below competitor catheters. Europe EP grew ~25% with both Volt and TactiFlex Duo on the market, and a Volt launch in Japan in 4Q should turn Japan from a headwind into a tailwind. TactiFlex Duo received FDA approval earlier than expected in September and moves through a short limited market release to a full US launch in 4Q. EP is guided to ~20% in 4Q as the LAA headwind grows ahead of US Amulet 360 approval expected in December, with some potential stocking in 1Q27. The ~18% 2027 guide assumes China VBP starts January 1 on the ~5% of EP sales in China. Amulet 360 pivotal data comes at TCT, and a trial against NOACs likely reads out in 2028.
- **Structural Heart sales of $592M (+2.6%cc, +6.9% comparable) missed by $2M, an improvement from +5.7% comparable in 2Q. A soft US (-2.3% comparable, -$11M) was mostly offset by OUS (+13.5% comparable, +$9M).** US MitraClip and TriClip remain under pressure from Edwards, while both held up well OUS. Structural Heart is guided to ~4% comparable growth in 4Q, which assumes some continued US comeptitive headwind, and ~5% in 2027. A mitral replacement valve and a balloon-expandable TAVR are in the pipeline.
- **Rhythm Management and Vascular beat while Heart Failure and Neuromodulation missed, with the Heart Failure shortfall concentrated OUS and the Neuromodulation shortfall in the US.** Rhythm Management sales of $752M (+10.0%cc) beat by $10M on increased AVEIR adoption across the single- and dual-chamber pacemaker segments, as OUS (+11.0% comparable, +$13M) more than offset a slightly light US (+9.0%, -$3M). CRM is expected to be ~10% in 4Q and ~7.5% in 2027, and a conduction system pacing lead is entering trial. Heart Failure sales of $387M (+6.0%cc) missed by $9M, with US growth of +8.4% (-$2M) offset by an OUS decline of 1.6% comparable (-$7M), and the business is guided to ~6.5% in both 4Q and 2027. Vascular sales of $786M (+5.7%cc) beat by $12M on OUS (+7.1% comparable, +$11M), while the US grew +3.4% (+$1M). Abbott has filed for approval of its coronary intravascular lithotripsy (IVL) device, developed from the CSI acquisition, and expects approval in 1H27. Management sizes the market at $1B+, and a peripheral IVL trial starts at year-end. Vascular is

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guided to ~4.5% in 4Q and ~5% in 2027. Neuromodulation sales of $251M (-1.1%cc) missed by $12M on a 5.6% US decline (-$15M), while OUS grew +13.9% comparable (+$3M), and it is guided flat in 4Q and to ~3% in 2027.

- **Diagnostics sales of $3.31B (+6.4% comparable) beat consensus by $16M, with the US $10M above and OUS $6M above.** Core Laboratory sales of $1.44B (+5.4% comparable) beat by $12M on balanced growth across the US, Europe, Japan, and Latin America. Rapid and Molecular sales of $899M (+0.9% comparable) beat by $11M, returning to modest growth from -8.0% in 2Q, with the US $14M above and international $2M light. Cancer Diagnostics sales of $968M (+13.8% comparable) came in $8M light, with a July cybersecurity event costing ~1 point of growth, even as Cologuard grew mid-teens on new users, rescreens, and Care Gap programs. On reimbursemnt, for procedural reasons, Cologuard Plus currently sits in the CMS system at the original Cologuard rate of $508 rather than $592, and management is highly confident it resolves at $592 by early December. Core Lab is expected to be ~6% in 4Q and ~5% in 2027, and Rapid and Molecular to flat in both periods. Cancer Diagnostics is guided to ~14% in 4Q and ~12% in 2027, a step behing behind its previous mid-teens target.
- **Established Pharmaceuticals sales of $1.61B (+8.4% comparable) came in $4M below consensus, as Key Emerging Markets beat on double-digit growth in India and several Latin America and Asia Pacific markets was more than offset by a shortfall in Other.** Key Emerging Markets at $1.20B (+10.9% comparable) beat by $14M, while Other at $419M (+1.6% comparable) came in $18M light. EPD is guided to ~8% in 4Q and ~7.5% in 2027, consistent with 7.5-8% growth over the last five years. Biosimilars for biologics losing exclusivity in emerging markets add to the pipeline.
- **Nutrition sales of $2.26B (+4.9% comparable) beat by $47M, with growth across all four categories and upside in both the US (+7.9%, +$27M) and international (+2.8% comparable, +$20M).** Pediatric of $1.06B (+8.7% comparable) accounted for $43M of the beat, with US growth of +11.0% (+$26M) helped by WIC contract wins earlier this year and international up +6.0% comparable (+$16M). Adult of $1.20B (+1.8% comparable) beat by $4M on international (+1.0% comparable, +$4M), while the US grew +3.5% (+$1M). Sales rose $118M Q/Q, and Nutrition is guided to ~14.7% in 4Q and ~3% in 2027. Abbott also recorded a ~$670M pretax charge to resolve the Gill case and NEC claims on behalf of ~2,000 additional infants, which was backed out of adj. EPS.

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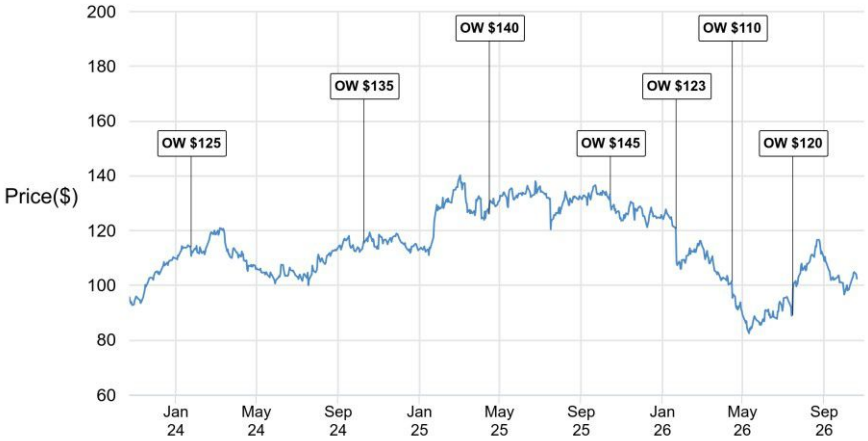
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Abbott Laboratories (ABT, ABT US) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price ($)	Price Target ($)
24-Jan-24	OW	114.00	125
10-Oct-24	OW	115.95	135
16-Apr-25	OW	126.22	140
15-Oct-25	OW	133.27	145
22-Jan-26	OW	120.73	123
16-Apr-26	OW	101.56	110
16-Jul-26	OW	89.27	120

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
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